



Ages 14 to 18

Online Abuse, Threats and Getting Help

What online abuse is, what the law says, how to report it safely, and how to help a friend. For all students.

Before You Read

This guide covers online abuse, threats and messages encouraging self-harm.

This guide is about online bullying and abuse, including threats of violence, messages encouraging self-harm, and abuse aimed at who someone is. Some of it may be difficult to read, especially if it connects with something that has happened to you or someone close to you.

- Read it in sections, take a break, or stop whenever you need to.
- You can talk to any adult you trust at school, including the safeguarding team, a counsellor or the school nurse.
- **Childline:** 0800 1111, free and confidential, any time, day or night. You can also use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk), but you may have to wait for a counsellor, so calling is usually quickest.
- **Shout:** text SHOUT to 85258, free, 24/7.

If you or someone else is in immediate danger, call 999.

This Guide Is for Everyone

This guide is for **all students**. It explains what online abuse is, what the law says, what to do if it happens to you or a friend, and how to report it safely.

- It can come from people you know, a group chat, or an anonymous account.
- **Anyone** can be targeted, and it's often aimed at who someone is.
- If it's happening to you, **it is not your fault**. If you've been part of it, you can stop and put it right.

Need Help Now?

- **Tell an adult you trust:** a teacher, your tutor, a house parent or anyone at school you feel safe with.

- If someone has threatened you or someone else, **tell an adult straight away**.
- If someone is telling you to hurt yourself, or you're thinking about it, **tell an adult now**, or contact Childline, Shout or Samaritans (116 123) any time.
- If someone is in danger right now, **call 999**.
- **Childline**: 0800 1111, free, any time.

Key Words

Cyberbullying

Bullying through phones, apps, games or the internet: repeated, deliberate hurting of someone with less power to stop it.

Online abuse

Any harm done online, including threats, harassment, humiliation and abuse aimed at someone's identity. It can be a single incident.

Pile-on

When lots of people join in against one person, by commenting, liking or sharing.

Anonymous account

An account that hides who is behind it. Anonymous doesn't mean a stranger.

Deepfake

A fake image, video or audio made or edited with AI to look real. The harm is real even when the content isn't.

Banter or Abuse?

The Difference

- Banter works when everyone is in on it and anyone can say "stop". It becomes bullying when it's aimed at one person, keeps happening, or they can't make it stop.
- Racist, sexist, homophobic, transphobic, faith-based or disability-based "jokes" are not banter. Schools must never treat abuse as "just having a laugh".
- **A pattern can help explain what is happening, but you don't need to wait for it to happen again before asking for help.** One threat, or one message telling someone to hurt themselves, is serious enough.

What the Data Shows

23%

of 8 to 17 year olds had experienced nasty or hurtful behaviour in the past year

Ofcom, 2026

26%

of 10 to 15 year olds who experienced online bullying told no one

ONS, 2020

The ONS figure is from the year ending March 2020, the most recent official statistics on online bullying. Checked September 2026.

Sources: check them yourself

- Ofcom, *Children and Parents: Media Use and Attitudes Report* (published 21 May 2026)
- Office for National Statistics, *Online bullying in England and Wales: year ending March 2020* (latest release)

What the Law Says

England and Wales

- **Not all bullying is a crime, but some online behaviour is.** Depending on what was sent and why, it can be a criminal offence to:
- send a message threatening death or serious harm, meaning someone to fear it will happen (Online Safety Act 2023);
- encourage someone to seriously harm themselves, or to take their own life, on purpose, even if they don't (Online Safety Act 2023; Suicide Act 1961);
- harass someone through repeated messages that alarm or distress them (Protection from Harassment Act 1997);
- target someone because of their race, religion, disability, sexual orientation or transgender identity, which can make an offence a hate crime (CPS);
- make, share or threaten to share nude or sexual images of anyone under 18, including AI-made ones.
- Criminal responsibility in England and Wales starts at 10. The police and courts decide whether a crime has happened, not you, and not school staff.

If you're the one being targeted, you won't be in trouble for asking for help. Schools treat this as a safeguarding matter first: their job is to keep people safe.

If It Happens to You

What to Do

- **Don't reply or retaliate.** Replying keeps it going, and hitting back could get you into trouble too.
- **Keep it.** Don't delete the messages. You don't need to save or screenshot anything: an adult can help keep the messages safely. **Never screenshot, save or forward a nude or sexual image.**
- **Tell a trusted adult.** If you need to block someone now to feel safe, do it, and tell an adult anyway.
- **Report.** Use the app's tools to report the message or post. An adult can help you do it.

It's Not Your Job to Investigate

- You don't have to find out who is behind an account, collect evidence, or monitor what's being said about you.
- Don't set up accounts to find out who it is or to get back at them.

Threats and Self-Harm Messages

Get Help Now

- **A threat to hurt you:** tell an adult straight away, especially if it mentions a time, a place, or where you live. If you're in danger, call 999.
- **Messages telling you to hurt yourself or end your life:** tell an adult now. The messages are designed to hurt; they say nothing true about you.
- If you're thinking about hurting yourself, talk to someone today: a trusted adult, **Childline** on 0800 1111, or text SHOUT to 85258.
- **NHS 111:** call 111 and choose the mental health option (option 2), for urgent mental health help in England, any time, or use NHS 111 online.
- If you've hurt yourself and need help, or you can't keep yourself safe, call 999.

If a friend shows you messages like this, or says they want to hurt themselves, **tell an adult straight away**, even if they ask you not to. That is how you keep them safe.

Reporting Safely

- **On the app:** report the message, post or account, and block it. Most platforms have a report button on messages, posts and profiles.
- **Report Harmful Content (UK Safer Internet Centre):** reportharmfulcontent.com, for anyone 13 or over in the UK, about threats, bullying and harassment, impersonation, self-harm or suicide content and other harmful content, once you have reported it to the platform and at least 48 hours have passed.
- **Report Remove (Childline and the Internet Watch Foundation):** helps under-18s get a nude or sexual image of themselves removed online, at childline.org.uk.
- **CEOP Safety Centre (National Crime Agency):** ceop.police.uk, for reporting online sexual abuse or grooming. It cannot deal with bullying, fake accounts or hacking. Use it if someone is asking for sexual images, trying to meet you, or you think an adult is contacting you sexually.

RESPOND: If It's Happening to Someone Else

Most online abuse has an audience. Bystanders decide whether it spreads or stops. RESPOND has three parts for students: **you lead the relational steps**, **Pause is the bridge**, and **adults lead the systems steps**.

Relational: You Lead (R, E, S)

R

Recognise

Notice what's happening.

- Use the 4 Ps: **People** (who's targeted, who's joining in?), **Places** (where does it spill over?), **Platforms** (which apps and chats?), **Patterns** (is it repeated, or getting worse?)
- You don't need certainty to act



Engage

Reach out privately.

- "I saw what was posted. Are you OK? You don't deserve that."
- **If it is safe to do so**, the best options are usually to **Delegate** (tell a trusted adult or report it), **Distract** (change the subject in the chat, or invite the person to do something else) and **Delay** (check in with them afterwards). Saying something directly, like "Not OK, leave it", is an option only if you can do it without becoming a target or making it worse



Support

Stay close.

- "I'm here. We can talk to someone together."
- Keep including them. Being left out is part of how bullying works

The Bridge: Pause (P)



Pause

Think before you act.

- Three questions: **Risk** (is anyone in danger?), **Rights** (what does the person need?), **Resources** (who can help?)
- **Don't share, screenshot, like or comment**, even to defend someone: it keeps the post visible
- Don't start a counter-attack or "expose" anyone. You're not expected to investigate or collect evidence

Systems: Adults Lead (O, N, D)



Offer

Model alternatives. Signpost help.

- Show a different way: don't join in, report it, and be kind in the chat
- Tell the person help is available, and offer to go with them



Notify

Tell a trusted adult.

- **Threats and self-harm messages: tell an adult straight away**
- It isn't snitching. It's how people get protected



Document

Adults record it.

- The adult makes the formal record. Tell them what you saw, and where



Telling an Adult

What Happens When You Tell

- **It starts with a person you trust. Behind them is a system:** a safeguarding team, records and procedures that make sure what you tell one person reaches the people who can help. The person is why young people tell; the system is why telling works.
- You'll be listened to and taken seriously.
- Adults won't confront anyone without a plan to keep you safe, and they'll think about how to protect anyone who reported it.
- The adult will pass it to the safeguarding team. They won't promise to keep it secret, and they'll tell you what they are doing.
- The law allows schools to share information needed to keep a young person safe without asking for consent, and from 30 September 2026 a new legal duty requires many safeguarding organisations to share it. What is shared must be relevant and proportionate, go only to the people who need it, and be handled in line with data protection law. Because your consent isn't the legal basis, they won't ask for it as if it were. They should tell you what they are sharing, with whom and why, unless that would put someone at risk, and listen to what you think. Agreeing to support, such as counselling, is a separate choice, and your views matter there.
- You'll have as much say as possible in the plan and the support you get.

Whoever You Are

- Abuse aimed at your race, religion, disability, sexuality, gender identity or background is taken seriously, and may be a hate crime.
- LGBTQ+ young people may face threats to "out" them. You can talk to a trusted adult about how this is handled. Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25): if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111.
- Fake or AI-made images of you are abuse, even though they aren't real. Don't try to prove they're fake: tell an adult.

If You've Been Part of It

Liking, sharing or adding a comment can make you part of a pile-on, even if you didn't start it. People join in to fit in, or so they're not next. Noticing that is the first step.

- Stop, and don't share it further. Don't delete things if an adult asks you to keep them.
- Talk to an adult you trust. Owning it early is better than being found out.
- Some online behaviour is a crime, and the consequences can be serious. The age and maturity of young people are taken into account, but you still need to take responsibility.
- **Childline** (0800 1111) is there for you too.

Myths and Facts

Myth	Fact
"It's just banter"	If it's aimed at one person and they can't make it stop, it's bullying. Abuse about who someone is is never banter.
"If it's anonymous, nothing can be done"	Adults can still act to keep you safe, and the police can investigate threats and other crimes.
"Screenshotting and sharing it helps"	Sharing spreads the harm. Tell an adult and

people see what's going on"

report it instead.

"Telling someone to hurt themselves is just words"

It can be a crime, and it can put a life at risk.
Tell an adult straight away.

If You Board

- You can always contact your house parents, the DSL or a member of the boarding management team, at any time, day or night.
- If messages arrive at night, tell the house parent on duty, even late. You don't have to wait until morning.
- Your boarding school has an independent person you can talk to who isn't a member of staff.
- You can always contact your family privately.

Who Can Help

At School

- Any adult you trust: your tutor or advisor, your head of year, a teacher, a coach, a house parent if you board, or a school counsellor
- **The Designated Safeguarding Lead (DSL)** and deputy DSLs: the staff whose job is to keep students safe. Their names are usually on the school website, in the safeguarding policy and on posters around school.
- The school nurse or health centre, and the school counsellor

Outside School

- **Childline (for anyone under 19):** 0800 1111, free and confidential; call any time, day or night, or use 1-2-1 chat at [childline.org.uk](https://www.childline.org.uk) (you may have to wait for a chat counsellor, so calling is usually quickest). **If you're under 18, start here.**
- **Shout:** text **SHOUT** to 85258, free, confidential, 24/7
- **Samaritans:** 116 123, free, any time, day or night

- **Galop Children and Young People's Service (LGBT+ young people aged 13 to 25):** if you are under 18, use the online referral form at galop.org.uk/make-a-referral, or call Childline on 0800 1111
- **Emergency:** call 999

RESPOND Safeguarding Framework Student Guides

Online Abuse, Threats and Getting Help: Student Guide 3 - 14 to 18

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